

The Rebate-Ready Garden

Lawn to Native Meadow Garden

Replace a patch of lawn with native flowers and grasses that bloom from spring to frost and never need mowing.

40 × 10 FEET · 89 PLANTS · FULL SUN · AVERAGE SOIL



Fig. 1. The bed from above, to scale. Each grid square is one foot. Circled numbers match the list at right.

THE IDEA

This plan turns a rectangle of lawn into a bed of native flowers and grasses. Rebate programs call it conservation landscaping or native planting, and many of them pay homeowners back for doing it.

Everything here is native to Maryland. It blooms in waves: golden alexanders and columbine in spring, bergamot, butterfly weed and mountain mint in summer, then asters and grasses into October. Monarchs, bumblebees and goldfinches all use it.

Page 4 shows what the program pays and how this plan meets its rules. Page 5 is the plant list, laid out the way the application asks, plus the photo and step checklist.

Take the lawn out by smothering it with cardboard and mulch, or by cutting the sod. Don't start until your application is approved.

WHAT TO BUY

- ☐ 5 Black chokeberry (1)
- ☐ 3 New England aster (2)
- ☐ 3 Switchgrass (3)
- ☐ 3 Indian grass (4)
- ☐ 12 Wild bergamot (5)
- ☐ 13 Virginia mountain mint (6)
- ☐ 6 Butterfly weed (7)
- ☐ 6 Black-eyed Susan (8)
- ☐ 6 Smooth blue aster (9)
- ☐ 7 Little bluestem (10)
- ☐ 15 Golden alexanders (11)
- ☐ 10 Wild columbine (12)

89 plants in all. Buy quart pots (3-gallon for shrubs); the programs want real plants, not seed. Ask for the straight species, not a named cultivar.

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PRINCE GEORGE'S COUNTY EDITION

HARDY IN ZONES 4-8 · PLAN NO. MD-05 · ORBITAL DESK LLC

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The Bed at a Glance



Fig. 2. Each plant at its typical height, drawn in flower. They don't all bloom at once; page 3 shows when each one does.

Meet the Plants

1. Black chokeberry

Aronia melanocarpa · 3–6 ft · Apr–May

Berries for birds in winter. Brilliant red fall color; very adaptable.

2. New England aster

Symphyotrichum novae-angliae · 3–6 ft · Aug–Oct

Late-season fuel for migrating monarchs. Pinch back in June for a shorter, bushier plant.

3. Switchgrass

Panicum virgatum · 3–6 ft · Jul–Sep

Seeds for birds. Tough screen; handles wet or dry.

4. Indian grass

Sorghastrum nutans · 3–6 ft · Aug–Sep

Seeds for birds. Golden plumes in late summer.

5. Wild bergamot

Monarda fistulosa · 2–4 ft · Jul–Aug

Bumblebees and hummingbird moths. Tolerates drought once established.

6. Virginia mountain mint

Pycnanthemum virginianum · 2–3 ft · Jul–Sep

One of the best plants for pollinator variety. Minty leaves that deer often pass over (not deer-proof).

7. Butterfly weed

Asclepias tuberosa · 1–2.5 ft · Jun–Aug

Monarch caterpillar host. Deep taproot; hates being moved. Great for dry, sandy spots.

8. Black-eyed Susan

Rudbeckia hirta · 1–3 ft · Jun–Sep

Many small native bees. Short-lived but reseeds freely.

9. Smooth blue aster

Symphyotrichum laeve · 2–4 ft · Sep–Oct

Late-season bees. Tidier than New England aster; good in dry beds.

10. Little bluestem

Schizachyrium scoparium · 2–3 ft · Aug–Sep

Skipper butterfly host. Blue summer blades turn copper-orange in fall.

11. Golden alexanders

Zizia aurea · 1–3 ft · May–Jun

Black swallowtail caterpillar host. Early yellow when little else blooms.

12. Wild columbine

Aquilegia canadensis · 1–2 ft · Apr–Jun

Early hummingbirds. Thrives in rocky, thin soil.

Can't Find One?

Nurseries sell out by June. Any of these will fill the same spot:

Black chokeberry → Common ninebark
(*Physocarpus opulifolius*)

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What Blooms When

	JAN	FEB	MAR	APR	MAY	JUN	JUL	AUG	SEP	OCT	NOV	DEC
1. Black chokeberry												
2. New England aster												
3. Switchgrass												
4. Indian grass												
5. Wild bergamot												
6. Virginia mountain mint												
7. Butterfly weed												
8. Black-eyed Susan												
9. Smooth blue aster												
10. Little bluestem												
11. Golden alexanders												
12. Wild columbine												

The Almanac: Looking After It

REMOVING THE LAWN

After approval, smother the grass with cardboard and 3–4 in of mulch for a few weeks, or cut the sod out. Call 811 before digging.

PLANTING

Plant in spring or early fall, straight through the mulch. Water every few days for the first month unless it rains.

THE FIRST YEAR

It'll look sparse. Pull weeds every two weeks; the plants fill in by year two.

MOWING

None. Cut the old stems to about a foot tall in late April and leave the stubs for nesting bees.

NEIGHBORS

A crisp edge (a stone border, a mown strip or a low fence) makes a meadow look intentional, and some programs ask for one in front yards.

KEEP IT WORKING

The program expects you to maintain the garden. Keep your receipts and before-and-after photos together in one folder.

SAFETY

Milkweed sap and lobelias are toxic if eaten (NC State Extension). Wear gloves when you cut milkweed, and keep pets and kids from chewing the plants.

Your Notes

Date planted _____ Where the nursery was _____

The Rebate-Ready Garden

Your Rebate Packet

Prince George's County · rules checked Sept 30, 2026

WHAT THE PROGRAM PAYS

Program rate \$5/sq ft · at most \$2,000 for 400 sq ft, if approved

Approval isn't guaranteed, and the rebate can never be more than what you actually spend, with itemized receipts; labor you do yourself doesn't count. Cap: \$6,000 per home (lifetime). Minimum size for this project: 250 sq ft. Programs covered: Rain Check Rebate (Prince George's County, run by the Chesapeake Bay Trust). Who can apply: Prince George's County, MD, except the City of Bowie, which runs its own stormwater program. If your town has its own program, check with it first.

THE RULES, AND HOW THIS PLAN MEETS THEM

Requirement	What the program asks	This plan
Minimum size	250 sq ft	✓ 400 sq ft
Plants	Mid-Atlantic native species	✓ 100% native to Maryland (USDA)
Spacing	Perennials 2 ft, grasses 2–4 ft, shrubs 4–6 ft	✓ Perennials and grasses 2 ft, shrubs 4 ft
The sketch	Existing house, trees, driveway; plant locations; density; plant list	✓ Fig. 1 plus the submission sheet; add your house and trees
Front yards	Include a visible edge (a border, path or low fence)	✓ Edge the front with stone, a path or a low border

MEASURING THE AREA

The rebate is paid on the square feet of lawn you convert. Stake out the bed (40 × 10 ft = 400 sq ft), take your 'before' photos with the stakes in, and keep them. A curved edge is fine; keep the same area.

THE SKETCH

Fig. 1 on page 1 is drawn to scale with every plant placed. On a copy, sketch in your house, driveway and any trees near the bed, and write in the distances. That, plus the plant list on page 5, is the planting plan the application asks for.

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Submission Sheet

The plant list, laid out the way the application asks for it. Attach it with Fig. 1.

#	Common name	Scientific name	Container	Qty	Spacing	Native
1	Black chokeberry	<i>Aronia melanocarpa</i>	3 gal	5	48 in	MD
2	New England aster	<i>Symphyotrichum novae-angliae</i>	Quart	3	24 in	MD
3	Switchgrass	<i>Panicum virgatum</i>	Quart	3	24 in	MD
4	Indian grass	<i>Sorghastrum nutans</i>	Quart	3	24 in	MD
5	Wild bergamot	<i>Monarda fistulosa</i>	Quart	12	24 in	MD
6	Virginia mountain mint	<i>Pycnanthemum virginianum</i>	Quart	13	24 in	MD
7	Butterfly weed	<i>Asclepias tuberosa</i>	Quart	6	24 in	MD
8	Black-eyed Susan	<i>Rudbeckia hirta</i>	Quart	6	24 in	MD
9	Smooth blue aster	<i>Symphyotrichum laeve</i>	Quart	6	24 in	MD
10	Little bluestem	<i>Schizachyrium scoparium</i>	Quart	7	24 in	MD
11	Golden alexanders	<i>Zizia aurea</i>	Quart	15	24 in	MD
12	Wild columbine	<i>Aquilegia canadensis</i>	Quart	10	24 in	MD

89 plants · 40 × 10 ft = 400 sq ft · 100% native to Maryland (USDA PLANTS) · no cultivars needed

Mulch: about 3.8 cubic yards at 3 in.

STEP BY STEP

- ☐ Apply online through the Chesapeake Bay Trust (Rain Check Rebate).
- ☐ Book the pre-installation site visit with the Rain Check coordinator.
- ☐ Send the pre-approval items: sketch, plant list, site photos, perc test (rain gardens) and the signed Property Owner Agreement.
- ☐ Wait for written approval. Don't buy or dig before it.
- ☐ Call Miss Utility (811) at least 3 business days before digging.
- ☐ Install within 12 months of applying. Keep every itemized receipt.
- ☐ Post-installation inspection, then submit receipts.
- ☐ The county mails a check, about 6–8 weeks after approval.

PHOTOS TO TAKE

- ☐ The lawn before, with the bed staked out
- ☐ The bed after the grass is removed
- ☐ Planting day
- ☐ The finished bed from the street or house
- ☐ A close-up showing plant spacing

KEEP IN ONE FOLDER

The approval letter, every itemized receipt (plants, mulch, compost, rented tools), your photos, and this packet.

SOURCES

cbtrust.org/grants/prince-georges-county-rain-check-rebate (page updated 9/11/26); Rain Check Rebate Application Instructions, 7.2.26; Rain Garden Fact Sheet and Guidelines, 3.2.26; Conservation Landscaping Pre-approval Guidelines, 4.7.26.

DISCLAIMER

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